passive protection measures become equally important—camouflage, concealment, dispersion, hardened shelters, underground facilities and redundancy of assets. Both active and passive measures must work together. Third, we will need greater civil-military coordination and infrastructure integration. In many cases, dual-use infrastructure and civil-military fusion will become important to optimise resources while enhancing resilience. Ultimately, the future battlefield will require integrated systems where drones, air defence, surveillance and command networks operate as a single ecosystem. Only then can we manage the offensive and defensive challenges posed by these rapidly evolving technologies.

Q. You have been planning to establish the theatre command system. Why is there a delay in implementation?
This reform is not merely administrative; it is fundamentally about warfighting. The challenge was never conceptual



agreement but integration. The services historically operated on separate networks, communication systems, maintenance protocols and organisational cultures. Jointness, in my view, is first a mindset. It is the confidence and willingness of officers and commanders across services to work together seamlessly. Integration is the next stage—physically connecting systems, networks, logistics and operational structures so that the three services can function as one cohesive force. Only after that can theatre commands truly succeed operationally. Earlier, each service chief was individually responsible for threats emerging in his own domain. Modern warfare has become multi-domain and extremely complex. Land, air, sea, cyber, space, electronic warfare and information operations are now deeply interconnected. No single service can fight effectively in isolation anymore. That realisation helped overcome much of the earlier resistance. Today, I would say there is broad consensus among the services on the way ahead. Some issues still remain under discussion, but the overall framework has largely matured. Recommendations have already been made to move forward with implementation. I believe that once formally approved, theatre commands could become operational within roughly two years.

Q. How would you assess the effectiveness of the Agniveer scheme?
The way we describe modern warfare, there could hardly be a better concept than the Agniveer scheme. It ensures that there is a cycle of renewal every four years in the force. In earlier structures, a soldier might serve for 15-16 years without that level of systematic rotation and technological refresh, and as the battlefield event changes, he risks being out of sync with the current realities of war. With Agniveer, the force is continuously infused with new-age personnel who are more aligned with evolving technologies and doctrines, while still maintaining a blend with experienced soldiers. This creates a healthy mix of experience and fresh perspective. Conceptually, it is a strong model for modern warfare, where adaptability and rapid learning are essential. It brings continuous renewal into the force structure and, in principle, it should succeed.

“If Pakistan thinks it acquired nuclear weapons to nullify the conventional asymmetry in India’s favour, they are mistaken. India is constantly improving and expanding the depth of our conventional response to their terror attacks, as illustrated from the strikes after Uri, Balakot and now Operation Sindoor”

Q. How do you balance self-reliance with urgent operational needs for equipment purchases?
Self-reliance today is no longer a separate objective—it is an operational necessity. In modern warfare, you are not just buying equipment; you are buying an ecosystem. If that ecosystem is externally controlled, it affects operational flexibility, security, upgrades and surprise. That is why self-reliance is directly linked to operational effectiveness. It ensures control over integration, upgrades and innovation within our own warfighting network. There is also a security dimension. In a network-centric battlefield, systems continuously generate and transmit data. External dependence can create constraints on autonomy and visibility. Aatmanirbharta, therefore, is essential for future military effectiveness. ■